

KEEP THIS ONE; IT LIVES NEXT TO YOUR SEND BUTTON

AI for Communication: The message before the message

THE STANCE

AI handles the ordinary contact. You still write the hard message.
AI drafts, the teacher decides.

The last-contact test

Pick one student, ideally one you find difficult. When did that family last hear from you when nothing was wrong? Not a grade in the portal, not a mass email. If the only contact a family gets is bad news, every message from school arrives as an accusation, and the hard conversation starts from a deficit you never meant to create.

Why the ordinary note is not soft

In a field experiment, weekly individualized teacher-to-parent messages cut the share of students failing to earn the course credit from 15.8% to 9.3%, a 41% reduction (Kraft & Rogers, 2015). **Say the scope with the number, every time:** this ran in a summer credit-recovery program, so those students were retaking a course they had already failed, and the study tested a bundle (individualized content, weekly frequency, improvement framing), so no single ingredient is proven to be the active one. Worth doing. Not proof that personalization is the mechanism.

The test that decides whether a note is worth sending

GENERIC

"Maya is doing well and it's a pleasure to have her in class."

Works with any child's name in it.

SPECIFIC

"Maya found the mistake in my worked example on Tuesday and said so in front of everyone."

Could only be about Maya.

The swap test: put another child's name in your sentence. If it still works, it is not a note yet. A tool can write the first sentence all day. It cannot write the second one, because it was not in the room on Tuesday.

Prompt 1 · The four-note shape (copy this)

"You are a teacher's writing assistant. Write four short positive notes home, one per student, three or four sentences each. Nothing is wrong. These are [grade] students, and these families mostly hear from school only when there is a problem. Do not invent anything about the students. Under 70 words each. Plain language, no exclamation marks, no praise adjectives. Leave one blank line in each note where I will write the specific true thing I saw this week. Label them Note 1 to Note 4."

The last sentence is the whole design, not a workaround: you are telling the tool to leave a hole in its own work, because the part that matters cannot come from it.

Where the one true detail comes from

Look at **this week**, not the whole year. Four days. You are looking for a moment, a sentence, or a choice, not an achievement, and it does not have to be academic. It has to be true, dated, and specific enough that a family can picture it. If you genuinely have nothing for a child this week, that is information too, and it is usually about who you are watching.

The hard message, which you write

The rule	What it sounds like
Lead with the fact	"Devon has not turned in three of the last four assignments" opens a conversation. "I'm concerned about his effort" opens an argument, because effort is an opinion and the family gets to have a different one.
Make one ask	One thing you want this family to do, stated plainly, with a date. Not four things.
Promise nothing you cannot deliver	If you do not know whether he can catch up, say you do not know. A promise you break in a hard message costs more than the message.
Know when to stop typing	Third paragraph, explaining your own feelings, or written angry: that is a phone call. Anything written angry waits until morning unless safety cannot wait.

Prompt 2 · The second read for tone (never the words)

"You are a careful editor who has never met my students. Read the message below and tell me only how its tone will land. Do not rewrite it. It goes to one family about missing work. The facts and the request are already correct and I am not changing them. No names are in it. List any sentence that reads as blame, sarcasm, or a promise I did not mean to make. Quote the sentence, name the problem in one phrase, and stop. No replacement wording."

You write the message. The tool reads it back. Strip every name before you paste anything in.

The red line: no public AI translation of family messages. You cannot review what you cannot read. Official and legal documents travel your district's translation channels, which is the district's obligation. Plain language in the original is how your message reaches every family.

The human-only list (never a message)

Safety · serious discipline · a family's grief · special-education news. For these you call, in your own voice. The written follow-up comes after the call, and it comes from you.

The permanent rules ride along: the situation goes into the tool, the child never does. Do not paste a parent's email in to get help replying; it is full of identity. Describe it instead, and add every specific yourself in your own inbox.

Lab step 1 · Four families who have not heard from you when nothing was wrong

Initials only. Beside each, the one true thing you saw this week.

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